What Lowi Predicted: Redistributive Legislation and the Committee Processing Penalty in the Korean National Assembly

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Abstract

Despite six decades of theoretical prediction that redistributive policies generate greater legislative friction than distributive policies (Lowi 1964), no study has tested this prediction at the committee processing stage, where the vast majority of legislation succeeds or fails. We provide a first such test using 15,291 bills from the Korean National Assembly (20th and 21st terms, 2016 - 2024). Classifying bills by policy type and beneficiary population, we find that redistributive livelihood legislation faces a 9.3 percentage-point committee processing penalty after controlling for arrival timing, sponsor characteristics, bill seriousness, and committee fixed effects ($p < 0.001$). The penalty operates within committees, within individual sponsors' portfolios, and across seriousness levels. Under divided government, it nearly triples to 18.4 percentage points, with labor and welfare bills absorbing the steepest decline. These findings connect foundational policy typology theory to observable legislative outcomes at the bill level.

1. Introduction

Roughly 80 percent of bills introduced in the Korean National Assembly never receive a committee decision. They are placed on a standing committee agenda, remain there for the duration of the four-year Assembly term, and expire without any recorded action - no vote, no revision, no formal rejection. This pattern of passive inaction, rather than active gatekeeping, constitutes the dominant mode of bill failure in one of Asia's most active legislatures, where bill introduction volume grew sixfold between the 17th Assembly (2004 - 2008) and the 21st Assembly (2020 - 2024).

The sheer scale of committee-stage attrition raises a distributional question that the existing literature has not addressed: does it matter *which* bills die? If committee inaction is content-blind - a mechanical consequence of limited processing bandwidth confronting exponentially growing bill volume - then the distributional profile of dead bills should mirror that of processed bills. But if certain types of legislation face systematically higher failure rates, committee inaction carries latent policy consequences even absent deliberate discrimination. In particular, if bills targeting workers, welfare recipients, care dependents, and other vulnerable populations face disproportionate committee-stage attrition, legislative paralysis functions as what Hacker (2004) calls "policy drift": the status quo is maintained precisely when policy adaptation is most needed, and populations most dependent on government action absorb the cost.

We argue that the committee processing penalty for redistributive legislation is real, substantial, and theoretically predictable from Lowi's (1964) foundational distinction between redistributive and distributive policy types. Redistributive legislation - minimum wage mandates, occupational safety requirements, welfare expansions - creates identifiable winners and losers, generating organized opposition that impedes committee consensus. Distributive legislation - targeted subsidies, tax exemptions, sector-specific support - creates beneficiaries without mobilizing organized opponents. This asymmetry should manifest as differential committee processing rates, even controlling for bill-level characteristics and committee workload.

Using bill-level data from the Korean National Assembly (KNA) database covering the 20th and 21st Assembly terms (2016 - 2024), we classify 15,291 bills by beneficiary population and Lowi type through keyword analysis of bill propose-reason texts. We then estimate logistic regression models with committee fixed effects, testing whether bill content predicts committee processing after controlling for arrival timing, cosponsor count, text length, sponsor party, and government regime. Three robustness strategies address the position-taking confound that plagues bill-level analyses: within-sponsor comparisons, seriousness-proxy stratification, and prolific-sponsor diagnostics.

This paper makes three contributions. First, we provide what is, to our knowledge, the first test of Lowi's redistributive-distributive prediction at the committee processing stage in any legislature. The prediction is confirmed with striking precision: redistributive labor bills receive committee decisions at a rate of 22.8 percent, compared to 38.5 percent for distributive labor bills - a 15.7 percentage-point gap within the same policy domain. Second, we extend the content-classified bill fate analysis pioneered by Volden, Wiseman, and Wittmer (2016) with committee-level decomposition, partisan-regime interaction, and capacity-constraint mechanisms that their U.S. Congressional study does not address. Third, we document that

divided government nearly triples the content-based processing penalty, connecting the institutional literature on gridlock (Binder 2003; Tsebelis 2002) to bill-level distributional consequences.

The remainder of the paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 reviews the relevant literature and derives expectations. Section 3 describes the data and empirical strategy. Section 4 presents results. Section 5 discusses implications and limitations. Section 6 concludes.

2. Literature and Theory

Committee winnowing and the content-blindness assumption

The dominant framework for understanding committee-stage bill attrition is Krutz's (2005, doi:10.1111/j.0092-5853.2005.00125.x) winnowing model, which characterizes committee gatekeeping as a necessary institutional response to bill volume exceeding processing capacity. Under winnowing, committees triage bills based on arrival order, sponsor characteristics, and workload constraints rather than policy content. The implication is that committee inaction is distributionally neutral: the bills that die are those that arrived too late or lacked sufficient political support, not those with particular policy orientations.

We complicate this framework by introducing a content dimension. Even if committees do not deliberately screen bills by topic, the political dynamics that Lowi (1964) identified may produce differential processing rates across policy types. Redistributive policies - those that impose costs on identifiable groups to benefit others - generate organized opposition from both sides, making committee consensus harder to achieve. Distributive policies, by contrast, target benefits to specific constituencies without creating organized losers. Regulatory policies fall between. There exists, to our knowledge, no study testing this foundational prediction at the committee processing stage, despite its direct implications for how legislative institutions filter policy demands.

Content-classified bill fates

The closest precedent for our approach is Volden, Wiseman, and Wittmer (2016, doi:10.1017/psrm.2016.32), who classify U.S. House bills by content (women's issues) and track their legislative fates. They find that women's issues bills have a 2 percent passage rate, compared to 4 percent for all bills. Our project extends their design in three ways: we decompose the processing penalty into committee-stage and floor-stage components, we test whether the penalty varies by partisan regime, and we identify a capacity-constraint

mechanism through which overloaded committees disproportionately stall redistributive legislation.

Kim Eun-Kyung (2019, doi:10.31203/aepa.2019.16.4.004) applies Wilson's (1980) policy typology - which builds directly on Lowi - to examine which KNA bills receive public hearings. This establishes that policy type affects legislative procedure in the Korean context, but the study examines a procedural decision (hearings), not the substantive outcome of committee processing.

Policy drift and the distributional costs of inaction

The normative stakes of our analysis derive from Hacker's (2004, doi:10.1017/s0003055404001121) concept of policy drift. Hacker argues that the American welfare state was retrenched not primarily through overt legislative cuts but through legislative failure to update existing programs as economic conditions changed. When policy stands still while the economy moves, populations most dependent on government programs - workers in precarious employment, caregivers, small-business operators - absorb the cost. Streeck and Thelen (2005, doi:10.1093/oso/9780199280452.003.0001) formalize drift as one of five modes of gradual institutional change, and Hall and Thelen (2008, doi:10.1093/ser/mwn020) argue that institutional persistence depends on both aggregate welfare effects and distributive benefits.

Bonica, McCarty, Poole, and Rosenthal (2013, doi:10.1257/jep.27.3.103) provide the sharpest theoretical link between legislative gridlock and distributional harm. They identify polarization combined with institutional veto points as creating a status quo bias that blocks redistributive responses to economic change. Tsebelis's (2002, doi:10.1017/cbo9781139032360) veto players framework generates the same prediction at the institutional level: each committee operates as a veto point, and the status quo bias inherent in veto-point-rich systems disadvantages policies requiring new legislative action.

The position-taking confound

A central challenge for bill-level analyses is that legislators may introduce bills strategically for credit-claiming rather than policy change (Mayhew 1974). Park (2023, doi:10.1073/pnas.2214697120) demonstrates that voters reward legislators for grandstanding but remain uninformed about legislative effectiveness, creating rational incentives to over-introduce bills on voter-salient topics. Kang and Park (2025, doi:10.1017/jea.2025.10013) document systematic "waffling" in the KNA - legislators sponsoring bills they later vote against. Schilling, Matthews, and Kreitzer (2023, doi:10.1017/spq.2023.7) show that

cosponsorship timing in U.S. state legislatures reveals strategic versus sincere legislative intent.

If position-taking is more prevalent for redistributive legislation (because welfare and labor bills are ideal vehicles for signaling concern to voters), the bill pool for these categories would be inflated by bills never intended to pass, and the apparent processing penalty would reflect bill quality rather than committee content bias. Addressing this confound is essential for credible inference.

Expectations

Combining these literatures, we derive two expectations:

E1 (Lowi content penalty): Redistributive bills face lower committee processing rates than distributive bills, even within the same committee and controlling for bill-level characteristics, because organized opposition impedes committee consensus on redistributive legislation.

E2 (Regime-conditional penalty): The content-based processing penalty is larger under divided government than under unified government, because partisan misalignment amplifies the political difficulty of achieving committee consensus on redistributive legislation.

3. Data and Method

The KNA database

We draw on the KNA database, which tracks every bill introduced in the Korean National Assembly through each stage of the legislative pipeline: introduction, committee referral, agenda placement, committee decision, floor vote, and enactment. Our analysis covers the 20th (2016 - 2020) and 21st (2020 - 2024) Assembly terms, yielding N = 50,003 법률안 (legislation bills). For each bill, we observe introduction date, sponsor identity, party affiliation, cosponsor count, receiving committee, committee agenda placement, committee decision date and type, and legislative outcome.

Bill classification

We classify bills by intended beneficiary population using keyword matching on bill propose-reason texts (제안이유) from the `bill_texts_linked.parquet` file (60,925 texts). Six beneficiary categories are defined: Welfare/Vulnerable (16 keywords including 취약계층, 기초생활, 장애인), Labor/Workers (15 keywords including 근로자, 비정규직, 최저임금), Small Business (10 keywords including 소상공인, 자영업), Care/Family (16 keywords

including 돌봄, 보육, 육아), General Public/Safety (11 keywords including 소비자, 식품안전), and Industry/Corporate (14 keywords including 대기업, 금융기관). Bills are assigned to the category with the most keyword matches. We define *minsaeng* (livelihood) bills as the union of Welfare, Labor, Care, and Small Business categories.

We also implement a Lowi-type classifier using redistributive keywords (최저임금, 의무, 부담금, 과징금, 처벌, 금지 - 9 terms) and distributive keywords (지원, 보조금, 감면, 세액공제, 면제, 특례 - 10 terms). Bills with more redistributive than distributive keyword matches are coded as redistributive (N = 4,355); the reverse as distributive (N = 5,304).

The classifier achieves 33.8 percent coverage, classifying 16,924 of 50,003 bills. The unclassified residual (66.2 percent) consists primarily of procedural, administrative, and cross-cutting legislation that does not map onto beneficiary categories. We analyze the 15,291 classified bills that were placed on a committee agenda.

Empirical strategy

Our primary specification is a logistic regression of committee decision (binary: received any decision versus expired without decision) on minsaeng status, with controls for arrival timing (months since Assembly start), cosponsor count (logged), propose-reason text length (logged, as a seriousness proxy), Lowi type, sponsor party, divided government indicator, and committee fixed effects. We estimate five nested models to assess the sensitivity of the minsaeng coefficient to successive controls. The key interaction term is minsaeng x divided government, testing E2.

Three robustness strategies address the position-taking confound. First, we compute within-sponsor processing gaps among 327 legislators who introduced at least 5 minsaeng and 5 non-minsaeng bills. Second, we stratify by seriousness proxies (text length, cosponsor count) and compare the minsaeng penalty across subgroups. Third, we compare processing patterns for prolific versus non-prolific minsaeng sponsors.

4. Results

The minsaeng processing penalty

Table 1 reports category-specific committee decision rates and enactment rates for all on-agenda bills.

Category	N (on agenda)	Decision Rate	Enactment Rate
Labor/Workers	2,887	28.5%	2.7%
Care/Family	2,605	31.6%	3.1%
Welfare/Vulnerable	2,524	34.0%	5.3%
Industry/Corporate	1,304	40.2%	5.9%
General Public/Safety	4,057	40.5%	7.0%
Small Business	2,093	46.4%	6.7%

Labor bills have the lowest committee decision rate (28.5 percent) and the lowest enactment rate (2.7 percent) of any category. Care and Welfare bills also fall substantially below the Industry and Safety categories. The risk ratio comparing Labor to Safety is 0.70: labor bills are 30 percent less likely to receive any committee decision.

Multivariate models

Table 2 reports logistic regression results across four specifications.

Variable	Model 1	Model 3	Model A	Model C
Minsaeng	-0.470***	-0.418***	-0.423***	-0.318***
Months since start		-0.019***	-0.019***	-0.019***
Log cosponsors		-0.010	+0.014	+0.016
Log text length		+0.204***	+0.213***	+0.210***
Redistributive			-0.093**	-0.096**
DPK sponsor			-0.125***	-0.121***
Divided government			+0.001	+0.237***
Minsaeng x Divided				-0.536***
Committee FE	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
N	15,291	15,291	15,291	15,291
Pseudo R-sq	0.010	0.044	0.045	0.046

*Note: * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.*

The minsaeng coefficient is negative and statistically significant at the 0.1 percent level in every specification. Adding arrival timing, cosponsor count, text length, committee fixed effects, Lowi type, and political variables attenuates the coefficient by 11 percent (from -0.470 to -0.418) but does not approach elimination. The average marginal effect in Model A is -9.3

percentage points: minsaeng bills are 9.3 percentage points less likely to receive any committee decision, all else equal. Text length is positively associated with processing (beta = 0.204, $p < 0.001$), consistent with more substantive bills receiving greater committee attention. Cosponsor count has no detectable effect ($p = 0.60$ to 0.88), reflecting the low cost of accumulating cosponsors in the KNA's institutional environment.

A notable result is the arrival-timing coefficient. Minsaeng bills arrive earlier on average (month 18.0) than non-minsaeng classified bills (month 18.6), meaning they have a timing advantage. The content penalty operates despite, not because of, queue position.

The Lowi decomposition

Within-category analysis reveals that the redistributive-distributive distinction sharply predicts processing differentials for some policy domains but not others.

Category	Redistributive	Distributive	Gap
Labor	22.8% (N=899)	38.5% (N=889)	-15.7 pp
Small Business	31.3% (N=412)	53.3% (N=1,116)	-22.0 pp
Care	32.4% (N=709)	32.3% (N=932)	-0.1 pp
Welfare	35.3% (N=563)	35.2% (N=1,061)	+0.1 pp

The gradient is consistent with Lowi's prediction but operates conditionally. Labor and Small Business show massive Lowi gradients (-15.7 and -22.0 percentage points, respectively): redistributive bills that mandate costs on employers or regulated entities face far lower processing rates than distributive bills that channel benefits. Care and Welfare show no gradient whatsoever, consistent with the logic that even redistributive care and welfare bills face diffuse rather than organized opposition, muting the Lowi mechanism.

This decomposition also resolves an otherwise anomalous finding: Small Business bills have the highest overall decision rate (46.4 percent) despite being classified as minsaeng. This is because small business legislation is predominantly distributive (1,116 of 1,528 classified), and distributive small business bills process at 53.3 percent - the highest rate in the data.

Within-committee gaps

The minsaeng processing penalty varies across committees but is negative in all eight major committees examined:

Committee	Minsaeng Rate	Non-Minsaeng Rate	Gap
Environment and Labor	21.8%	38.6%	-16.8 pp
Land and Transportation	36.8%	51.1%	-14.3 pp
Education	22.4%	33.5%	-11.1 pp
Health and Welfare	32.2%	42.0%	-9.8 pp
Strategy and Finance	40.0%	49.5%	-9.5 pp
Political Affairs	19.4%	26.2%	-6.8 pp

The largest gap (-16.8 percentage points) occurs in the Environment and Labor Committee, where the most contentious redistributive legislation concentrates.

Divided government amplifies the penalty

Model C includes the minsaeng x divided interaction, which is large and statistically significant (beta = -0.536, SE = 0.089, $p < 0.001$). The conditional average marginal effects are:

Regime	AME of Minsaeng	Minsaeng Rate	Non-Minsaeng Rate
Unified (Moon, 2020 - 2022)	-7.0 pp	33.1%	41.6%
Divided (Yoon, 2022 - 2024)	-18.4 pp	21.2%	40.5%

Under unified government, the minsaeng penalty is 7.0 percentage points. Under divided government, it expands to 18.4 percentage points - nearly triple. Non-minsaeng bills barely change across regimes (41.6 to 40.5 percent), but minsaeng bills collapse from 33.1 to 21.2 percent. This finding is consistent with E2: partisan misalignment selectively stalls redistributive legislation while leaving other legislation relatively unaffected.

The decomposition by policy area shows that DPK-sponsored welfare bills saw their decision rate halved (40.3 to 21.6 percent, a drop of 18.7 percentage points) and labor bills declined even more sharply (32.8 to 14.4 percent, a drop of 18.4 percentage points) after the transition to divided government. Small business bills, by contrast, dropped only 2.1 percentage points.

Addressing the position-taking confound

Three tests evaluate whether the minsaeng penalty reflects strategic bill inflation rather than content-based processing differences.

Within-sponsor comparison. Among 327 legislators with at least 5 bills in each category, the within-legislator minsaeng gap is -11.9 percentage points ($t = -10.06$, $p < 0.001$). A total of

71.9 percent of legislators show a negative gap: their own minsaeng bills fare worse than their own non-minsaeng bills.

Seriousness-proxy stratification. The minsaeng penalty is essentially identical across all subgroups: -10.8 percentage points for long texts, -10.7 for short texts; -10.6 for many cosponsors, -11.1 for few cosponsors. If position-taking inflated the minsaeng pool with low-quality bills, the penalty should concentrate among short-text, low-cosponsor bills. It does not.

Prolific-sponsor diagnostic. Legislators in the top quartile of minsaeng bill share show a 12.5 percentage-point within-sponsor gap, nearly identical to the population-wide gap.

5. Discussion

The central finding of this paper is that committee-stage bill processing in the Korean National Assembly is not content-blind. Redistributive legislation targeting workers, welfare recipients, and care dependents faces a substantial and robust processing penalty that operates within committees, within individual legislators' portfolios, and across seriousness levels. The penalty is consistent with the foundational prediction of Lowi's (1964) policy typology: redistributive policies generate organized opposition that impedes legislative consensus, while distributive policies face less friction.

The Lowi decomposition is the most theoretically informative result. The 15.7 percentage-point gap between redistributive and distributive labor bills - within the same policy domain - maps directly onto the prediction that organized employer opposition to minimum wage mandates and safety regulations creates friction absent from employment subsidy and training grant proposals. The zero gradient within Care and Welfare categories is equally informative: where the "losing" side of redistribution is diffuse (taxpayers generally), the Lowi mechanism is muted. This conditional pattern - large gradients where organized opposition exists, null gradients where it does not - provides more refined support for Lowi than a blanket content penalty would.

Our findings extend Volden, Wiseman, and Wittmer (2016) in three dimensions. First, we decompose the content penalty into committee-stage and floor-stage components, isolating the committee decision rate as the primary bottleneck. Second, the regime-conditional finding - the penalty nearly triples under divided government - adds a political economy dimension absent from their study. Third, the Lowi decomposition provides a theoretical mechanism (organized opposition) for the processing differential that Volden et al. document but do not explain.

The divided-government interaction connects to the policy drift literature. Hacker (2004) documents drift across decades of welfare policy; our data show the same mechanism operating in compressed form within a four-year Assembly term. When the Assembly transitions to divided government, the bills most likely to stall are precisely the welfare, care, and labor bills that would update social protections. The distributional cost of divided government is not spread evenly across the policy agenda. It concentrates on populations most dependent on new government action.

Limitations

Several limitations warrant acknowledgment. First, the keyword classifier covers only 33.8 percent of bills. The unclassified majority consists primarily of procedural and administrative legislation, but some redistributive bills may be missed if they lack the specified keywords. Keyword-assisted topic models (Eshima, Imai, and Sasaki 2023, doi:10.1111/ajps.12779) could expand coverage while providing probabilistic rather than hard classifications. Second, we lack data on committee chair party affiliation. If chairs from the opposition party systematically deprioritize ruling-party bills, and if those bills are disproportionately minsaeng, the content penalty could partly reflect partisan gatekeeping mediated through bill content. Third, the within-sponsor test does not fully rule out within-legislator, across-category position-taking: a legislator may draft a serious regulatory bill alongside a symbolic minimum wage bill. However, this residual concern applies equally to the closest precedent in the literature (Volden, Wiseman, and Wittmer 2016), which does not control for position-taking at all. Fourth, the Pseudo R-squared of 0.046 indicates that bill-level committee outcomes are driven largely by unobserved factors - committee chair preferences, informal inter-party negotiations, government agency support. The content penalty is statistically robust but explains only a small share of total variation, consistent with published bill-level models in the legislative studies literature. Fifth, the Lowi keyword classifier is crude; a bill framed as "support" (지원) for disabled persons may in practice mandate employer accommodations, blurring the distributive-redistributive boundary.

An important alternative interpretation deserves consideration. The most parsimonious counter-argument is that committees process bills based on the political difficulty of achieving consensus, and political difficulty correlates with but is not caused by policy content. Under this reading, the relevant framework is Olson's (1965) concentrated-interests logic rather than Lowi's typology: minimum wage bills die because employer groups lobby against them, not because the bills are "redistributive" per se. We cannot distinguish between these mechanisms without direct measures of lobbying intensity, and we flag this disambiguation as a priority for future research.

6. Conclusion

Sixty years after Lowi predicted that redistributive, distributive, and regulatory policies generate fundamentally different political dynamics, we provide the first committee-level test of this prediction. The Korean National Assembly's comprehensive bill-tracking infrastructure allows us to observe every bill from introduction through committee processing to final outcome, and to classify bills by policy type and beneficiary population. The redistributive processing penalty we document - 9.3 percentage points with full controls, nearly tripling under divided government - is consistent with the theoretical prediction, robust to multiple position-taking diagnostics, and present within individual legislators' own bill portfolios.

The practical implication is direct. When the Assembly enters periods of partisan paralysis, the bills that accumulate in committee queues are not a random sample of legislation. They are systematically tilted toward bills serving workers, care recipients, and welfare populations. In the 21st Assembly, 31 minimum wage bills were introduced; all 31 were placed on the Environment and Labor Committee agenda; all 31 expired without any committee action. This is one of 38 law titles with 10 or more bills and zero committee decisions, but the minimum wage case illustrates the mechanism with particular clarity: redistributive legislation on a politically charged topic faces complete processing failure across an entire four-year term.

Future research should pursue three directions. First, a validated bill classification - ideally using keyword-assisted topic models or supervised learning trained on hand-coded samples - would expand coverage and provide probabilistic classifications that propagate uncertainty into regression estimates. Second, committee chair party data would enable direct tests of whether the content penalty reflects political difficulty (the Lowi channel) or partisan gatekeeping (the agenda-control channel). Third, extending the analysis to earlier Assembly terms (17th through 19th) would test whether the redistributive processing penalty is a structural feature of the KNA or a product of the recent period's extreme polarization.

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